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THE GREAT WALL OF CHINESE ANTAGONISM



INDIA MUST FACE UP TO CHINA'S UNABATED HOSTILITY TOWARDS IT. FACTS SUGGEST XI JINPING HAS MADE A CHOICE AND IS PLANNING FURTHER MILITARY OPERATIONS AGAINST INDIA

In the decade following the global economic downturn, the world order has been undergoing gradual change. Emerging powers like India and Japan have sought greater voice in international organisations, including at the United Nations. However, the process was rudely disrupted, first by the Covid pandemic and later, in February 2022, when Russian president Vladimir Putin decided to accelerate the pace of change by attempting to unilaterally alter international boundaries and invade Ukraine. Putin was emboldened after the February 4 summit with his ally, Chinese president Xi Jinping. Assured of China's tacit support, he withdrew his forces from the border with China and redeployed them on the Ukrainian front.

Both Putin and Xi are keen to see the emergence of a new world order. China's official news agency Xinhua quoted Xi as saying that "China and Russia are committed to deepening strategic cooperation and safeguarding international fairness and justice". He added that this is "a strategic decision that has far-reaching consequences for China, Russia and the world, and will not be shaken".

Russia's war with Ukraine has brought China's intentions into sharper focus. Beijing had long sought to be recognised as a power on par with the US. It had unsuccessfully proposed "a new type of great power relationship" where the two powers become joint arbiters of global disputes. Under Xi, China trumpeted its global ambitions. Xi hastened the modernisation of China's armed forces and, in 2012 and 2017—at two successive Party Congresses—spelt out China's goals: surpassing the US and achieving the "rejuvenation of the Chinese nation" by 2049, the 100th anniversary of the nation's founding. The latter implied recovering territories that China claims to have lost because of "imposition of unequal treaties by hostile foreign powers". In 2013, Xi unveiled the Belt and Road Initiative, an expansive geo-economic strategic initiative that was quickly augmented by the Maritime and Digital Silk Roads, which he envisioned as extending China's power to straddle the globe with a China-built communications artery. But before it can become a superpower, China needs to dominate the Indo-Pacific region, where India is the largest power.

China's expansionist agenda and aggressive foreign policy have a direct bearing on India. Official Chinese maps depict large portions of sovereign Indian territory, like Ladakh, portions of Kashmir, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh and almost the entire state of Arunachal Pradesh as part of China. China also claims nearly 90 per cent of the South China Sea, encroaching